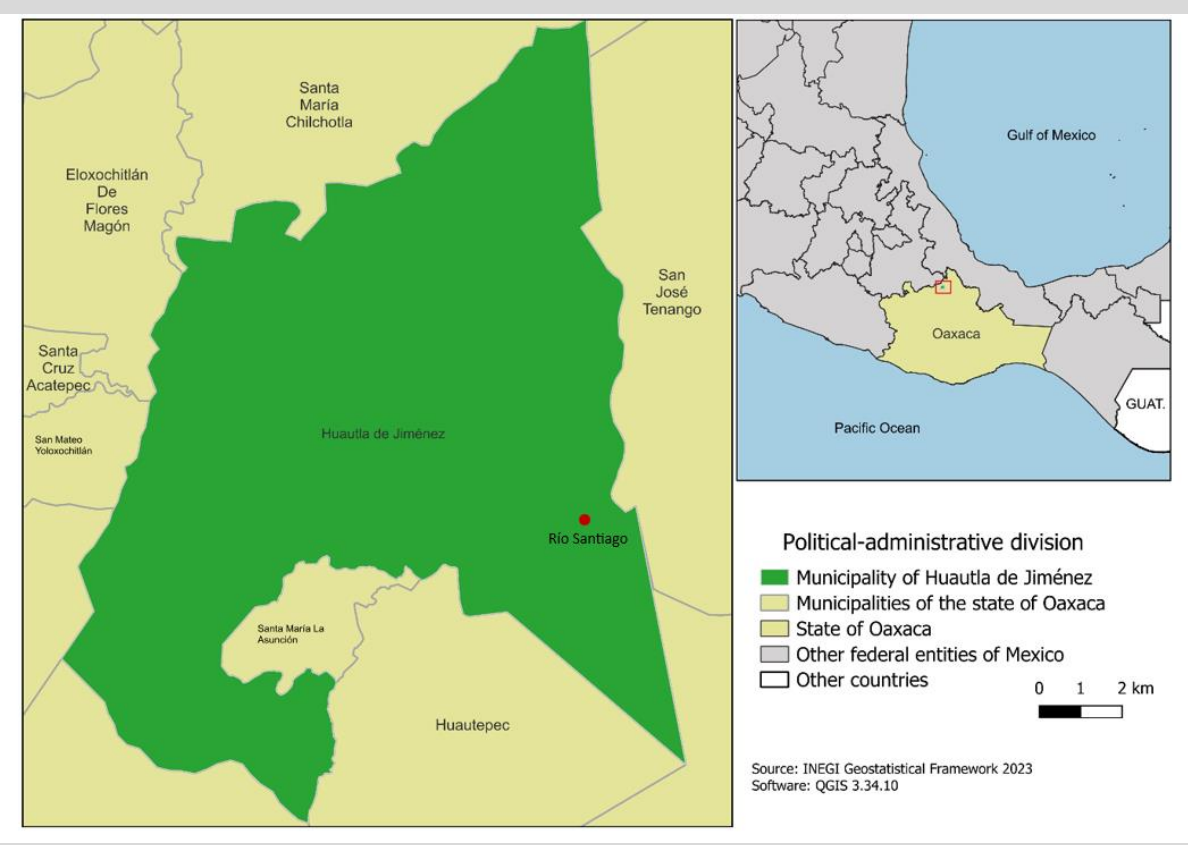




Introduction

Forest fires are a critical socio-environmental challenge in Mexico. There are, on average, 21,000 fires per year affecting more than 677,000 hectares, and Oaxaca is one of the most affected states. (Martínez & Rodríguez).

In 2024 the state of Oaxaca had 274 fires (the tenth highest level in Mexico), causing 160,438 ha of burned area (the third highest level in the country). In the Sierra Mazateca, more than 20 forest fires were recorded in almost a month: municipalities such as San José Tenango, Huautla de Jiménez and Mazatlán de Flores were severely affected. In the municipality of Huautla de Jiménez, fires affected 33,4862 ha of cloud forest (Government of Mexico, 2024). This has generated serious ecological and social impacts, including the destruction of flora and fauna, the loss of fertile soil for crops such as milpa and coffee, and health problems in the population, in addition to emotional damage. The magnitude of the damage has led communities to demand that the government declare a disaster area and send urgent specialized resources (Piña & Valdés; 2024).

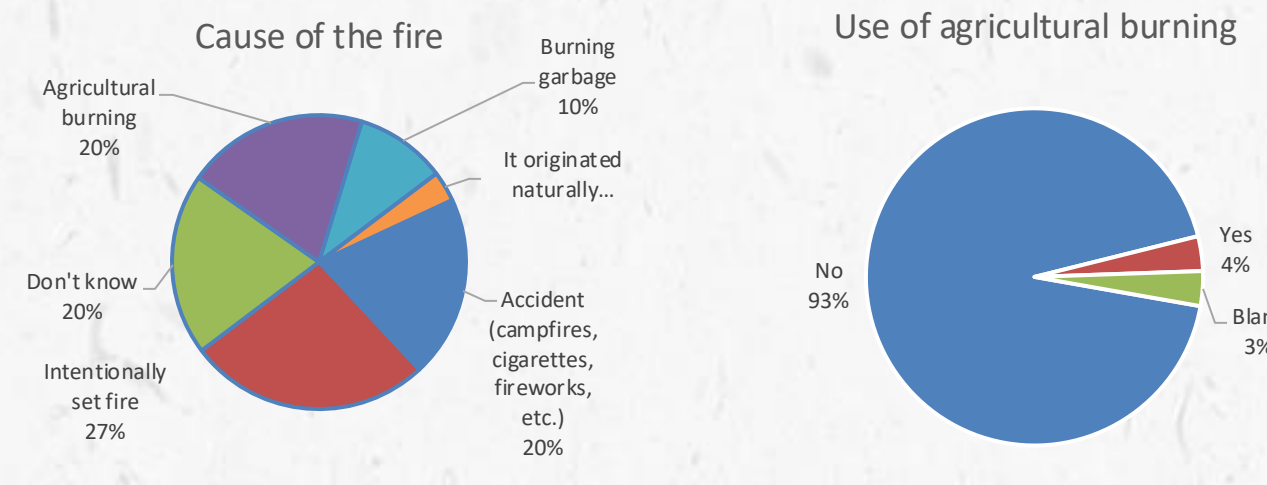
This work seeks to publicize the perceptions of the affected population, in order to encourage the creation of an intercultural agenda that offers community participation

Methodology

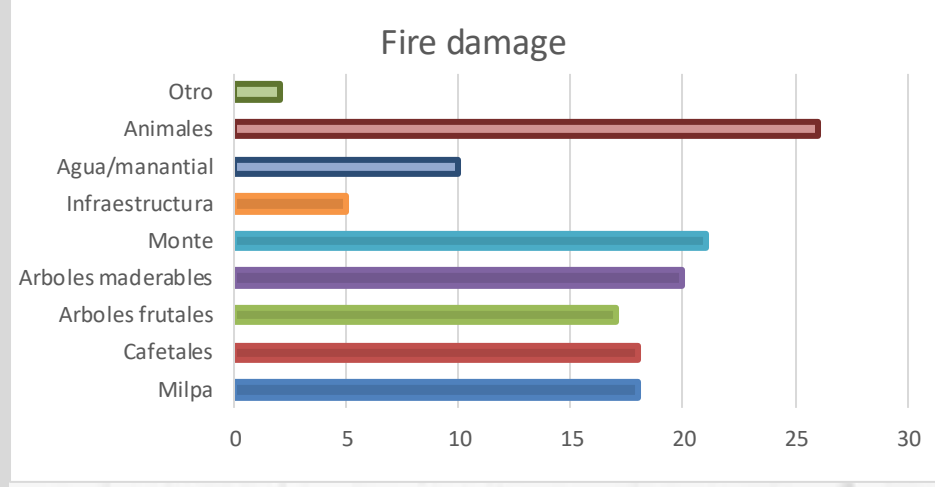
A mixed methodology (qualitative and quantitative) was applied through surveys to 30 household representatives from the community of Río Santiago, belonging to the municipality of Huautla de Jiménez. This with the aim of evaluating the ecological and social impacts of the fires that occurred between May and June 2024. The selection of this community was based on two criteria: due to the severity of the fire, classified from moderate to high according to the analysis carried out in 2024. by the previous relationship with the community, derived from the educational and environmental awareness activities carried out with children and young people.

Results

- Causes:** 27% of the interviewees consider that the cause of the fire was intentional, in contrast to 93% of the interviewees who deny the use of burning for planting within the community. This suggests that the cause is not directly linked to the practice of slashing, slashing, and burning, but to external or intentional factors.



- Fire damage:** for more than 80% of the interviewees, the main damage was recorded in: (i) animals, (ii) the forest and (iii) timber trees.

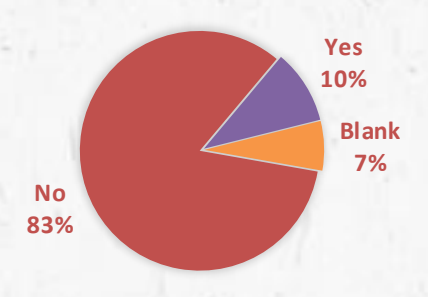


This reflects a high valuation of the fauna and the surrounding ecosystem, beyond direct productive resources

- Climate change:** Interviewees say they have noticed that "it's hotter" in the community.

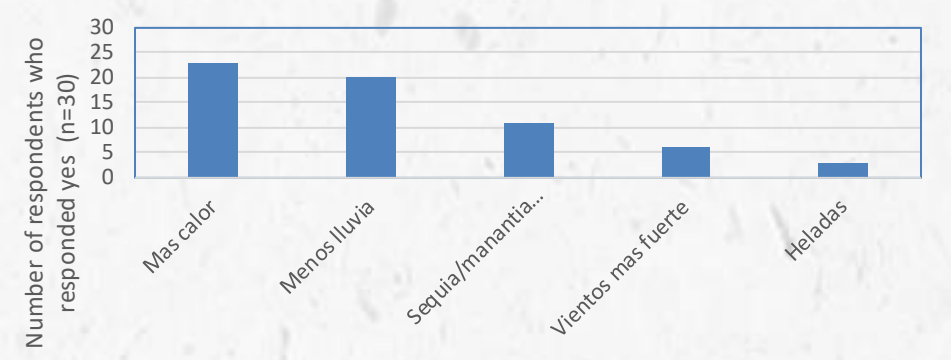
- Training:** 83% of respondents stated that they had not received any training on fire management. This lack of training is alarming in the face of the climate changes that are occurring around the planet.

FIRE MANAGEMENT TRAINING



- 43% of respondents are concerned about hot seasons and
- 66% say they are poorly prepared to adapt to sudden changes in the climate.

Climate changes in the community



Final Thoughts

This initial study in Río Santiago found that the community has a **high perception of climate risk**, but at the same time a **very low preparation to face it** (66% feel unprepared). The results challenge the common narrative that blames the peasantry for the fires:



Causes: A significant portion (27%) attribute fires to intentionality, not accidents.

Agricultural practices: The community almost unanimously denies the use of agricultural burning. Prevention efforts should focus on other real causes rather than criminalizing local practices.



Biocultural connection: The community reports a high emotional impact and prioritizes damage to fauna and forest, demonstrating a deep connection with their territory that can be a key driver for conservation.

Despite being an exploratory study, the findings validate the **urgency of immediate action**. Thus, it is essential to: (i) Implement **comprehensive training** on fire and climate change, and (ii) Develop an **intercultural agenda** that integrates the community, academia, and institutions (such as CONAFOR/CONANP) to create robust fire management policies.



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